

Comments for Planning Application DM2025/01591

Application Summary

Application Number: DM2025/01591

Address: Ambulance Station Dorset Road Belmont SM2 6JH

Proposal: Change of use from Sui Generis (Ambulance Station) to mixed use Classes F1 (Places of Worship) and F2 (Community Hub) involving the erection of a part one, part two storey front and side extension, increase in height to part of building and provision of cycle and refuse stores.

Case Officer: Polly Davidson

Customer Details

Name: Dr M Alamu

Address: 1 Kenilworth Terrace 89 Worcester Road Sutton SM2 6JQ

Comment Details

Commenter Type:

Stance: Customer made comments in support of the Planning Application

Comment Reasons:

Comment:

Planning Department

London Borough of Sutton

Civic Offices, St Nicholas Way

Sutton, SM1 1EA

RE: Planning Application Support - DM2025/01591

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Dear Planning Officer,

I am writing to express my strong support for the above planning application to transform the former Ambulance Station on Dorset Road into a mixed-use Place of Worship (Class F1) and Community Hub (Class F2).

I am writing this letter strictly in my personal capacity as a local resident; however, my views are deeply informed by my experience serving in a governance capacity within the local education sector.

I see firsthand the pressing need for supplementary community infrastructure in this borough, and I support this application on the following material planning grounds:

1. Direct Support for Local Educational Growth and SEN Provision

The F1/F2 designation allows this site to act as a vital supplementary space for educational growth in the borough. With the new Sutton special school slated to open in the near future, this Community Hub could serve as an invaluable auxiliary space. It has the immense potential to be utilised for the assessment of base provision-offering a neutral, welcoming environment for Special Educational Needs and Disabilities (SEND) assessments, early interventions, and parent-support meetings outside of a formal, school setting.

2. Partnerships with Sutton's Local Academy Trusts

Through my governance experience, I am acutely aware of the pressure on local school facilities and the constant need for accessible, neutral community partnership spaces. High-performing local educational networks across the borough-such as the Greenshaw Learning Trust (GLT), LEO Academy Trust, and Cirrus Academy Trust, etc.- frequently require off-site venues to facilitate pupil outreach, after-school mentoring, and localised family support programs. By approving this F1/F2 Community Hub, the Council will be providing a safe, dedicated space that these mainstream educational trusts can partner with.

3. Addressing the Shortfall in Youth Provision and Supplementary Education (e.g., 11-Plus, 6th formers, etc)

It is well documented that severe budget pressures and funding cuts have forced the closure of open-access, Council-run youth centres across Sutton. Consequently, the borough now relies heavily on the voluntary and community sectors to fill this critical gap. Approving this Community Hub will provide a safe, dedicated space for young people across a wide age spectrum. For younger pupils, it can serve as a vital venue for 11-plus tuition; given Sutton's highly competitive grammar school system, there is a massive local demand for affordable, community-based spaces to host these preparation groups. Furthermore, for older youths, it will serve as an essential environment where 6th formers, apprentices, and those in vocational training can access study support, mentoring, and positive social engagement during evenings and weekends.

4. Alignment with Local Healthcare Objectives - Epsom and St Helier University Hospitals NHS Trust & The Royal Marsden Hospital

A dedicated Community Hub (Class F2) at this location presents a vital opportunity to support the preventative health and community care objectives of both the Epsom and St Helier University Hospitals NHS Trust and The Royal Marsden Hospital, which is located right here in Belmont. The NHS relies heavily on community infrastructure for "social prescribing"-directing vulnerable residents, including the elderly and those recovering from long-term illnesses, to local support groups to combat isolation, loneliness, and cognitive decline.

This site is perfectly positioned to host elderly day clubs, dementia support cafes, well-being drop-in sessions, and provide a quiet, accessible space for outpatient support groups and families navigating care at the nearby Royal Marsden.

5. Relieving Pressure on Existing Oversubscribed Community Assets

It is well known that existing community hubs in the borough, such as the Thomas Wall Centre, are frequently overbooked and operating at maximum capacity. Approving this new hub in Belmont will provide a much-needed, localised backup facility. When the Thomas Wall Centre is fully booked, this site can serve as an essential overspill location for vital services like general after-school tuition, specifically benefiting Belmont families who currently have to travel into central Sutton for these activities.

6. Sustainable Transport, Environmental Impact, and Waste Management

The site benefits from excellent public transport accessibility due to its close proximity to Belmont Railway Station and highly connected local bus networks. Specifically, the S2 bus runs directly via Dorset Road-passing the secondary gate of Avenue Primary School and routing through York Road-while the S4 service travels along Holland Avenue, traversing the Dorset Road junction before continuing via Avenue Road to its final destination. This exceptional connectivity, alongside dedicated cycle stores, actively promotes sustainable travel.

Furthermore, the dedicated refuse stores align perfectly with the Sutton borough objective of waste recycling, ensuring that segregated waste can be processed into green, usable products. The modernisation of this building also presents the opportunity to deliver an eco-friendly facility utilising modern, solar-powered components, delivering a significantly reduced carbon load compared to the previous 24/7 ambulance depot.

7. Regeneration of a Redundant Site, Visual Amenity, and Local Character

Rather than leaving a vacant commercial building that could fall into disrepair, this proposal brings a brownfield site back into active, positive use. The new design blends perfectly into the ambiance of the neighbouring properties. Upgrading the current utilitarian structure with the proposed part-one and part-two storey extensions will modernise the site without compromising the existing local architecture, positively contributing to the visual amenity and overall streetscape of Dorset Road.

8. Protection of Residential Amenity (Compared to Existing Use)

When assessing potential noise or traffic impacts on neighbouring properties, it is highly material to compare the proposal against the site's existing established use. As a Sui Generis Ambulance Station, the site inherently accommodates 24/7 operations, emergency sirens, large vehicle

movements, and unsociable shift patterns. A transition to an F1/F2 Community Hub will introduce more structured, predictable hours of operation, resulting in a net-reduction in 24/7 noise and vehicular disruption for the immediate residential neighbours.

Conclusion

This proposal turns an obsolete building into a vibrant, multi-functional community asset. Whether it is supporting Sutton's major academy trusts, hosting local 11-plus tuition and 6th form study groups, providing vital backup capacity for the Thomas Wall Centre, facilitating local NHS and Royal Marsden support groups, or simply reducing the 24/7 disruption of the previous ambulance depot, this development represents a massive net-benefit to Belmont and the wider borough.

I strongly urge the planning committee and officers to recommend this application for approval.

Yours faithfully

Dr Alamu

Local Resident (SM2, I live within the vicinity of the proposed site)